

THE RAM

Aries



SIZE RANKING 39

BRIGHTEST STAR
Hamal (α) 2.0

GENITIVE Arietis

ABBREVIATION Ari

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
November–DecemberFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–58°S

This not particularly conspicuous constellation of the zodiac is found between Pisces and Taurus. Its most recognizable features are three stars near the border with Pisces: Alpha (α), Beta (β), and Gamma (γ) Arietis, of 2nd, 3rd, and 4th magnitudes.

Aries depicts the golden-fleeced ram of Greek legend (see panel, below). Over 2,000 years ago, the vernal equinox—the point at which the ecliptic crosses the celestial equator—lay near the border of Aries and Pisces. The effect of precession (see p.64) has now moved the vernal equinox almost into Aquarius, but it is still called the first point of Aries.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

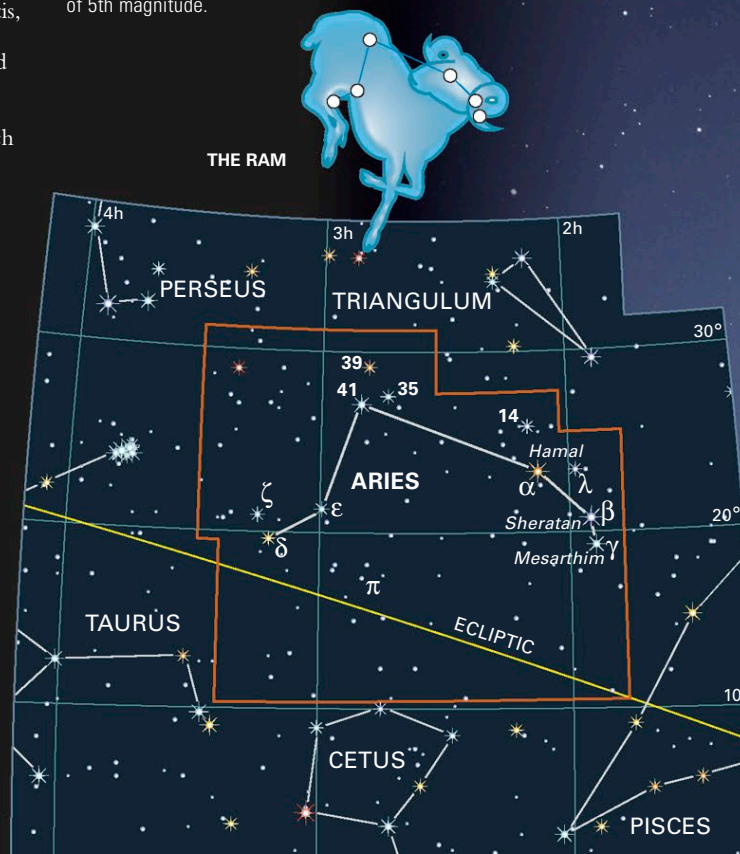
Gamma was one of the first stars discovered to be double, and it was found by the English scientist Robert Hooke in 1664, when telescopes were still quite crude and it was not realized that double stars are numerous. To the naked eye, it appears of 4th magnitude, but when viewed through a small telescope it consists of nearly identical white stars of magnitudes 4.6 and 4.7.

Lambda (λ) Arietis, of 5th magnitude, has a companion of 7th magnitude that can be seen through large binoculars. Pi (π) Arietis, also of 5th magnitude, has a very close companion of 8th magnitude.

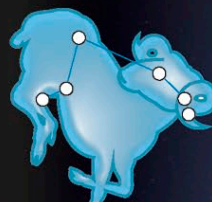


EASY DOUBLE ✎

Gamma (γ) Arietis is readily separable by a small telescope to reveal a pair of white stars, each of 5th magnitude.

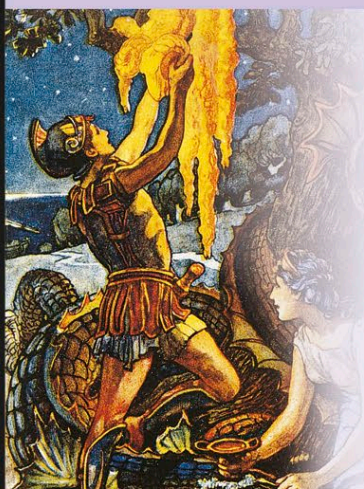


THE RAM



MYTHS AND STORIES

THE GOLDEN FLEECE



Aries represents the ram whose golden fleece hung on a tree in Colchis on the Black Sea. Jason and the Argonauts undertook an epic voyage to bring this fleece back to Greece. Jason was aided in his task by Medea, who had fallen in love with him. She was the daughter of King Aeetes, who owned the fleece. Medea bewitched the serpent guarding the fleece so that Jason could steal it. Taking Medea and the fleece with him, Jason then sailed away in the *Argo*.

GOLDEN MOMENT

Watched by an admiring Medea, Jason removes the glittering fleece from the oak tree on which it hung at Colchis, in this illustration by L. du Bois-Reymond.

LEGENDARY RAM 🐏

From a crooked line formed by three faint stars, ancient astronomers visualized the figure of a crouching ram, with its head turned back over its shoulder.